Dhawan's refusal to take the French offer of the HM-7 cryogenic engine in the mid-1970s. Having developed electronic propulsion to an advanced stage, the French have now saved up to 1.5 tonnes on payload.

R S Bhute, another of the Muthunayagam recruits, made himself appear to be a man of mysteries. Asked by colleagues what he was working on, Bhute would squint, James Bond-like, and say, 'Some chemicals.'

He often reminded me of an old man I had met in a nineteenth century tavern of a whiskey maker in Scotland in the early 1970s. The tavern, which doubled up as a dining place, served unlimited drinks and food for ten pounds. They also had this custom of designating, every night, the guest who had come from the farthest place their chief guest who got everything free. Having come from India, I was the lucky chap.

The old man who hailed from the original family or the distillers, served me a drink, which he said was special. It was a mellow form of a whiskey, with a great taste. I asked for its name. He did not have one. I asked why they were not selling it.

'It's the best drink we've made, but it cannot be bottled. It's just not stable,' the old man said.

Bhute was not half as articulate as the old man in the Scotland tavern. One day he announced that he had come up with a new liquid propellant.

'What's that?' everyone wanted to know.

'I can't tell you.'

Nobody ever again asked Bhute about his alchemy. None of the new recruits were able to come up with a game-changing idea or project. Soon they left, one by one.

The cryogenic plan remained in cold storage till the early 1990s, but for some sporadic work done by small teams in ISRO. By 1991, when PSLV was in advanced stages of development, GSLV studies were also gaining pace, with three versions of the launch vehicle—Mark I, Mark II and Mark III—being on the drawing board. Still we did not have a cryogenic engine. We had to buy the technology from one of them. This was easier said than done, for buying technology doesn't happen overnight.